



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Language



Your notes

Question 1: Summary

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Your notes

How to Answer Question 1: Summary

How to Answer Question 1: Summary

Paper 1: Reading is the compulsory exam in the CIE IGCSE, and CIE examiners recommend that you complete the questions in the order they are set. Question 1 is split into two tasks: a comprehension task and a summary task. The summary task will be based on Text B in your reading insert.

The following guide will provide you with the information you need to answer **Question 1: Summary** to a high standard.

Overview

For this task, you will respond to one question about Text B. The question will test you on your ability to understand explicit and implicit meanings and ideas in a text, and to select and use information for specific purposes. It will also assess your ability to organise and structure your ideas in writing, use a range of suitable vocabulary and sentence structures and write accurately, with correct spelling, grammar and punctuation. The question is worth 15 marks in total and is broken down as follows:

Question	Assessment Objective tested	What this means	Marks
1(f) - reading objectives	R1: demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings R2: demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes R5: select and use information for specific purposes	Base your answer on both explicit and implied information in Text B	10
1(f) - writing objectives	W2: organise and structure ideas and opinions for deliberate effect W3: use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures appropriate to context	Write an answer of no more than 120 words. Summarise, in your own words and in continuous form (not note form), what you learn about the focus of the question in the text	5



W5: make accurate use of spelling, punctuation and grammar

The question, taken from the June 2022 exam paper, looks like this:

Read **Text B, *Tough Mudder***, in the insert and then answer **Question 1(f)** on this question paper.

(f) According to Text B, why did Jayden Dee want to take part in this particular event?

You must **use continuous writing** (not note form) and **use your own words** as far as possible.

Your summary should not be more than 120 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 5 marks for the quality of your writing.

Make sure you read the correct text

This is the focus of the question

Remember, this is a 15-mark question, but 5 of those marks are for the quality of your writing. Therefore, make sure your answer is clear, coherent and accurate

These are important reminders about how to write your answer

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Steps to success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering this question effectively:

1. Read the question and **highlight**:

- The command words (what you are instructed to do)
- The focus of the question (the words or phrases you have to look for in the text)
- When highlighting, take note of the word count guidance and make sure you are using the correct text (Text B)



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2. Scan Text B and highlight the evidence that answers the question:

- In the above example, this would be anything that tells you why Jayden Dee wanted to take part in the Tough Mudder event
- Disregard any information or extra details which are not directly relevant to the focus of the question:
 - In the above example, the focus of the question is on “reasons why” – you should therefore ignore any “reasons why not”

3. Plan your answer before you start writing:

- Use bullet points for this
- Make sure each idea in each bullet point is distinct and complete (you are not repeating yourself)

4. Write your answers according to the question instructions:

- Do not just copy whole paragraphs from the text, or use quotes from the text
- You must summarise using your own words as much as possible
- Remember, not all of the information will be explicit (obvious):
 - You will have to make some inferences or read between the lines

5. Re-read your answer when you have finished to check whether:

- It answers the question
- It makes sense
- It is accurate (correct any obvious spelling, grammar or punctuation errors)

You are advised to spend no more than 20 minutes on this question (including reading time).

Exam tips

- Read the command words and the question carefully:
 - This will allow you to demonstrate a thorough understanding of the requirements of the task
- Make sure that you demonstrate that you understand a range of ideas in the text, as relevant to the focus of the question
- Write your answer in paragraph form, expressing yourself clearly, fluently and concisely:
 - Explain the ideas in a way that someone who had not read the text themselves would understand
- Do not just copy from the text or use quotes – this is not a language analysis question



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- Try not to repeat the same idea - the examiner can only credit you once
- When summarising, you should use Standard English:
 - Therefore, if Text B is written using a more informal register, adapt this to a more formal style suitable for a written summary
- Start your answer with a focus on the question:
 - Do not waste time on unnecessary introductions
- As you read Text B, highlight a range of ideas from different parts of the text:
 - Then re-organise them more efficiently for the reader
 - You do not need to work through the ideas in the order they appear in the text
- It is a very good idea to make a brief, bulleted plan of your answer before you start writing:
 - This will help you structure your response concisely
- Ensure you do not write too little or too much:
 - 120 words is approximately half a page of A4 in average handwriting

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).

For more advice on how to apply the skills required for success in this question, please see our [Question 1 skills: How to summarise](#) revision notes. For a model answer to this question, please see [Question 1 Summary: Model answer](#).



Your notes

Question 1 Skills: How to Summarise

Question 1 Skills: How to Summarise

Question 1(f): Summary on Paper 1 of your IGCSE tests you on your ability to understand and use explicit and implicit information in a text, and to summarise that information in your own words.

The sections below will explain what summarising is and how to summarise information successfully.

What is summarising?

Summarising is an important literacy skill, useful not just for your IGCSE in English Language. When you summarise, you are expressing the most important facts or ideas from a text in shortened form, using your own words. A summary should effectively explain all of the important information in a text in a clear and concise way, taking only the information that is directly relevant and ignoring less important details.

The key elements of a summary are:

- **Objectivity:** a summary sticks to the facts and is unbiased
- **Concision:** a summary should condense the important information, leaving out unnecessary detail
- **Structure:** a summary should be well-organised, preferably in chronological order, so that it is as clear as possible
- **Accurate:** the information provided in a summary needs to be correct and reliable

The summary you have to produce in your exam for Question 1(f) needs to get across the information the examiner requires in a clear and accurate way. This means that you need to distinguish between the important information and the irrelevant information in the text. However, while summarising as a skill normally allows direct repetition of the words in a text, for this task in the exam you are asked to write in your own words as far as possible. In this way, this task is actually a combination of summarising and **paraphrasing**, which means rearranging a text and putting it into your own words.

How to summarise in the exam

To complete this task effectively in the exam, it is essential that you understand exactly what you are being asked to summarise. Let's consider what exactly you are being asked to summarise in this example of Question 1(f) from the June 2020 exam paper:

Exam question	What you need to do
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According to Text B, what made Lyuba such a remarkable and precious scientific specimen and what did scientists hope to discover by studying her?	Here, there are two things you are being asked to summarise: - What made Lyuba such a remarkable and precious specimen - What scientists hoped to discover by studying her
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Once you have broken down the question, it is possible to go back to the text and identify the information directly relevant to the two bullet points above. Working through the text in logical order will help you to structure your summary. Let's look at how to do this, using the first three paragraphs of the text:

Text	Important information (relevant to the focus of the question)
Only a handful have been found before. But none like her. Her name is Lyuba. A one-month-old baby mammoth, she walked the tundra about 40,000 years ago, then died mysteriously. Discovered on a riverbank in Siberia, she's the most perfectly preserved woolly mammoth ever discovered. Lyuba has mesmerised the scientific world with her arrival - creating headlines across the globe. "Waking the Baby Mammoth", a new television programme, tells the tale of this single accidental discovery of a frozen baby mammoth in the Siberian tundra and how the discovery has enriched our understanding of these extinct magnificent beasts. The programme begins with the incredibly fortunate discovery of Lyuba by a reindeer herder who feared that disturbing the remains of the dead might lead to a curse. Too often with such findings, the preserved creature would be dug up and sold, leading to irreversible decomposition and the loss of a treasure trove of valuable information. However, the herder had enough foresight to contact authorities, and scientists began the careful retrieval process. Everyone wanted to know how Lyuba had died. What could she tell us about life during the Ice Age and the Earth's changing climate?	<i>What made Lyuba such a remarkable and precious scientific specimen:</i> - Only a handful of mammoths have ever been found - Most perfectly preserved woolly mammoth ever discovered - Discovered by accident - The man who found her did not disturb her remains or try to sell her - Scientists were able to carefully retrieve her, avoiding damage



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What scientists hope to discover by studying her:

- Better understanding of these extinct beasts
- How she died
- What life was like during the Ice Age
- Information about climate change

Summarising in continuous form

Normally, when you summarise from a text, you can choose the most appropriate format in which to present your information, such as bullet points. However, in the exam, you are asked to use continuous writing and your own words. Therefore, you need to structure your answer into clear paragraphs, ensuring that you still convey the important information listed above.

A good way to start this is by using the wording of the question. For example:

“Lyuba was such a remarkable and precious scientific specimen because...”

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You then need to start with the first point from the text, but consider how to modify the words in order to make them your own. For example:

“Lyuba was such a remarkable and precious scientific specimen because so few woolly mammoths had ever been found before.”

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It is also useful to make good use of connectives in order to link your points, to give a sense of overall **coherence** to your answer. For example:

“In addition, the mammoth’s body was in the best condition that had ever been recovered.”

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Examiner Tips and Tricks

Ensure that you cover all of the important points, and avoid any unnecessary information, such as Lyuba being the subject of a new television programme. This won't get you any marks.

A full model answer to a sample Question 1(f) can be found in the [Question 1 Summary: Model answer](#) page.



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Question 1 Summary: Model Answer

Question 1 Summary: Model Answer

Question 1 is split into two tasks: a comprehension task and a summary task. The summary task will be based on Text B in your reading insert, and is designed to test your ability to secure meaning from what you read, and write fluently and concisely in your own words.

The following guide will demonstrate how to answer the Question 1: Summary question from the June 2022 exam paper.

Text B (June 2022)

The following text is Text B taken from the June 2022 exam paper. It is about a sporting event called Tough Mudder, which is a long race with obstacles in it.

Text B: Tough Mudder

Jayden Dee is a participant in Tough Mudder, an obstacle course endurance race. In this article, he has been interviewed by his local newspaper, the Redmond Gazette (RG).

Jayden Dee knows about hard work and dedication, as the 27-year-old athlete and army captain is keen to prove. Despite missing the deadline to enter this year's Tough Mudder World Championship, airing on national television this weekend, he repeatedly emailed the company responsible for the event, asking to be included in the endurance contest. Eventually, they gave in and allowed Dee to compete.

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Tough Mudder isn't his first competition. Dee, who spent four years at a prestigious military school on a wrestling scholarship, competed in his first Ironman triathlon a few months ago. But the Tough Mudder event is something different altogether. It's billed as 'the most insane race around', featuring obstacles with names such as 'Kong' and 'Devil's Beard'. Participants bench-press sandbags, climb walls, crawl and run through mud, among other things that will make them wet, tired and dirty.

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Tough Mudder was held earlier this summer, with entrants competing for a substantial cash prize. We spoke to Dee beforehand about his preparation.

RG: How did you find out about Tough Mudder?

Dee: I found out online through social media, and I was like, 'I think I can compete with these guys'. I literally stayed up all night watching the one-hour special from last year's competition, and that's when I was hooked. I said to myself, 'I need to find a way to get into this.'

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RG: Is that typical of you?

Dee: Well I was super-competitive through school, and then I kinda needed a break, which was good because I went to Hawaii. So the last four years in Hawaii, I stayed active, but also made a point to relax. I always knew I'd come back and compete in something. I just was waiting for the right time. Then I did the Ironman competition and got the bug again. I was in really good shape when I found out about this event. It seemed like now was the time to come back.

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RG: How do you see yourself doing?

Dee: I want to win the whole thing! A lot of my role models, people I really look up to are in this competition, so I'm extremely realistic, but I also truly believe I can win. So I'm gonna do my best. I want to represent Redmond well. It's easy for people to forget where they come from, but I don't. This way while I'm home on leave I can get a chance to inspire kids as the 'Redmond Guy'.

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Question 1(f): Summary model answer

Below is Question 1(f) from the June 2022 exam paper:

Read **Text B, *Tough Mudder***, in the insert and then answer **Question 1(f)** on this question paper.

(f) According to Text B, why did Jayden Dee want to take part in this particular event?

You must **use continuous writing** (not note form) and **use your own words** as far as possible.

Your summary should not be more than 120 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 5 marks for the quality of your writing.

Based on the above question, the following model answer demonstrates how to use continuous writing to summarise information in your own words. It is an example of a full mark answer (15/15):



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Model answer:

Jayden Dee wanted to take part in this particular event because he likes to show people that he is hardworking and dedicated. He saw the Tough Mudder event as something challenging and original which appealed to his competitive nature. He saw it as different from other endurance events and had become obsessed with the idea of taking part by watching last year's event on television. He got hooked again on these events by competing in the Ironman competition, and because he felt really fit he thought the timing was right. He was inspired by the fact that a lot of people he looks up to take part in the event, and he wants to become an inspiration himself, representing Redmond and inspiring children from his hometown. Ultimately, he wanted to take part in Tough Mudder because he believed he could win.

The answer demonstrates understanding of both the text and the task

It remains focused on the task throughout (no unnecessary detail)

It provides a concise overview of all the main points in the text that answer the question

The response is well-organised, clear, fluent and accurately written

It uses the candidate's own words with well-chosen vocabulary

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Unannotated model answer

Model answer:

Jayden Dee wanted to take part in this particular event because he likes to show people that he is hardworking and dedicated. He saw the Tough Mudder event as something challenging and original which appealed to his competitive nature. He saw it as different from other endurance events and had become obsessed with the idea of taking part by watching last year's event on television. He got hooked again on these events by competing in the Ironman competition, and because he felt really fit he thought the timing was right. He was inspired by the fact that a lot of people he looks up to take part in the event, and he wants to become an inspiration himself, representing Redmond and inspiring children from his hometown. Ultimately, he wanted to take part in Tough Mudder because he believed he could win.

Commentary

- The answer demonstrates understanding of both the text and the task
- It remains focused on the task throughout (no unnecessary detail)
- It provides a concise overview of all the main points in the text that answer the question
- The response is well-organised, clear, fluent and written accurately
- It uses the candidate's own words with well-chosen vocabulary
- Whilst the response goes slightly over the 120 word limit, it is still concise and covers all of the points required



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Summary

- Remember to read the question carefully and highlight:
 - The instructions (what you have got to do)
 - The focus of the question (what you are being asked to write a summary about)
- Remember that up to five marks are awarded in this question for the quality of your writing:
 - Therefore, make sure you re-read your answer before moving on to the next question
- It is important that you are able to summarise mostly in your own words – do not just copy and paste from the text, or directly quote from the text
- This answer should be written in paragraph form – do not use bullet points or single words

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).